

TWELVE CARDS · ONE A MONTH

THE INSTRUMENT

Twelve tools for a life of your own making



LIMITED EDITION

ONE OF FIVE HUNDRED

One a month

- 01 On the first day of the month, read the chapter. Then take out the month's card.
- 02 Put it where you will see it without looking for it: the desk, the mirror, the inside of the wallet.
- 03 The front is the axiom. The back is the practice, in brief. The book has the rest.
- 04 Tick the boxes as you go. On the last day, return the card to the box and sign the ledger.
- 05 Keep the cards after the year. The three you kept are the instruments; carry those.

I

The Eulogy

Begin at the end.

Write the eulogy

- 01 ☐ Choose the speaker: the person whose good opinion you most want to have deserved.
- 02 ☐ Set the scene in one line. The year, the room, who is there.
- 03 ☐ Four hundred words in their voice. Not what you achieved: what it was like to know you.
- 04 ☐ Read it aloud once. Mark every sentence not yet true.
- 05 ☐ Extract three governing lines. They now outrank every goal you have.

II

The Weeks

A life is four thousand weeks. Spend them on purpose.

Fill the chart

- 01 ☐ Colour every week you have lived, in pen.
- 02 ☐ Find the line at eighty. Count the rows left; write the number.
- 03 ☐ The tail-end sum for three people: times a year, times years left.
- 04 ☐ Set the weekly non-negotiable: two hours, same time, twelve weeks in the calendar.
- 05 ☐ Cancel one weekly recurrence today.

III

The Question

The quality of a life follows the quality of its questions.

Fifty questions

- 01 ☐ Fifty questions about your own life, one sitting, no answering.
- 02 ☐ The next day, circle the three that made you uncomfortable.
- 03 ☐ For each, write the answer you are pretending not to know.
- 04 ☐ Find the eigenquestion: the one whose answer settles the others.
- 05 ☐ Carry it for the month. Do not force an answer.

IV

Inversion

Avoid stupidity before you attempt brilliance.

Run the premortem

- 01 ☐ Name the most important thing you are doing this year.
- 02 ☐ It is one year from today. It has failed completely.
- 03 ☐ Fifteen reasons, specific, in the past tense.
- 04 ☐ Circle three; one action this month against each.
- 05 ☐ Write the kill criterion and the not-to-do list.



Asymmetry

Make many small bets whose downside is bounded and whose upside is not.

Sort the bets

- 01 ☐ List every decision you have been putting off.
- 02 ☐ Mark each door. Decide every two-way door today.
- 03 ☐ One-way doors: what would have to be true, and the cheapest way to find out.
- 04 ☐ Ten small bets; place three this month.
- 05 ☐ Open the decision ledger: what I expect, and when to check.

VI

The Loop

You become whatever you get fast feedback on.

Shorten the loop

- 01 ☐ Name the three skills your governing lines require.
- 02 ☐ Measure each loop: how long until you know honestly how it went.
- 03 ☐ Take the longest and design it ten times shorter.
- 04 ☐ Run it for thirty days. Count the iterations.
- 05 ☐ Retrieve, do not re-read: write what the chapter said before opening it.

VII

Attention

Your experience is what you agree to attend to.

The thousand minutes

- 01 ☐ Three days in ten-minute boxes, one word each.
- 02 ☐ Colour what you would choose again. Count the rest.
- 03 ☐ Sacred hours: two a day, same time, phone in another room.
- 04 ☐ Close every session in one line: where I stopped, the next step.
- 05 ☐ Remove one input for the month.

VIII

Compounding

Small, repeated, for years, beats large, occasional, for months.

The ten-year letter

- 01 ☐ Name the one asset that, held ten years, changes everything.
- 02 ☐ Write the letter, dated ten years from today, from you to you.
- 03 ☐ Set the weekly minimum you could sustain for five hundred and twenty weeks.
- 04 ☐ Name what compounds against you. Start reducing it.
- 05 ☐ Keep the letter in the book. The envelope will ask.

IX

Taste

Quantity is the road to quality.

One hundred ideas

- 01 ☐ One hundred ideas, one sitting, no judging.
- 02 ☐ The next day, circle five by asymmetry.
- 03 ☐ Make the smallest version of one this week. Show one person.
- 04 ☐ Start the commonplace book: one page a day.
- 05 ☐ One hour made for every hour consumed.

X

The Ask

Most of the world is a door that opens if you knock.

Five asks in seven days

- 01 ☐ List ten asks you have been avoiding.
- 02 ☐ Rank by asymmetry. Pick five.
- 03 ☐ Ask within seven days. Write the answer, not the fear.
- 04 ☐ Write the letter you have been not writing. Send it.
- 05 ☐ Collect ten refusals before the month ends.

XI

The Body

The mind is something the body does.

Fourteen days of the four

- 01 ☐ Fixed wake time. The alarm is for bed, seven and a half hours before.
- 02 ☐ Daylight within an hour of waking. Ten minutes outdoors.
- 03 ☐ Thirty minutes of movement a day; three hard sessions a fortnight.
- 04 ☐ Five minutes of slow breathing when arousal is high.
- 05 ☐ Mark the grid nightly. Day fifteen: what changed?

XII

The Others

Good relationships keep us happier and healthier. Period.

The gratitude visit

- 01 ☐ Name the five. Beside each, the date of the last real conversation.
- 02 ☐ Three hundred words of gratitude to one of them.
- 03 ☐ Deliver it in person, and read it aloud.
- 04 ☐ The weekly call: one of the five, thirty minutes, twelve weeks.
- 05 ☐ Repair one thing. Have the postponed conversation.